

LN905 Pre-sessional Course

Academic Interaction Introduction



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Purpose



Participating in seminars & groupwork can be difficult for many international students.

Some reasons include:

- Not finding the **opportunity** to speak
- Not having the **time** to formulate a response
- Feeling unable to contribute something **interesting/relevant**
- Not wanting to **risk** saying something “wrong” (linguistic or academic)
- Lack of **confidence/experience** with public speaking

Academic Interaction



This class aims to provide time & space for you to practice interacting academically, especially:

- Speaking in a groups with other students
- Co-creating shared understanding of texts & issues
- Thinking of strategies to ensure you have something to say
- Techniques to help you gain & maintain the floor

These should boost your confidence with seminars & group work & hopefully benefit your studies in September. **It is also excellent preparation for your speaking exam at the end of the course.**

Format



Format



Each week you will all read a text, which will be related to the weekly topic input. Today, you'll discuss a Social Media text that you're familiar with, but future texts won't be covered in class.

These texts will also be used in your Friday Reading-into-Writing, so these sessions are a good opportunity to share ideas.

You'll be in groups of 4-7. Every student will have a different role, and your groups and roles will change every week to give you the chance to work with other classmates.

The roles are there to ensure that:

- 1) Everyone has something unique to contribute, and;
- 2) As a group, you'll have approached the text from several perspectives, which will enhance your overall understanding.

However, the aim of these classes is to promote a genuine discussion of the topic. It helps if you imagine you're having a conversation with some friends rather than a 'seminar'...

Consider the roles as useful guidelines rather than something that restricts your contribution.

Roles



Leader



You will start and control/direct the discussion but without turning it into a series of mini-presentations. Imagine you're a referee. You might need to stop it going too off-topic, or to encourage people to speak (using some open questions).

For this role, you should think of some questions about the text's key themes/points that you can use to facilitate the discussion. You're not expected to control this tightly, as all members should be focused on discussing not waiting for permission!

Connector



You will be connecting the information from this text to the other information you've studied in the week - in other words, synthesising. Does this text support information from the Topic Input, the Listening or the Reading class? What are the similarities or differences?

You could also link information from the texts to real-life situations that classmates will be familiar with or ask everyone questions based on this.

Evaluator



You will look at the article from a critical perspective and ask questions of the source. Is it well-cited? Is it recent, or if not, is it still relevant? Was their research thorough? Are there any issues with the *Methodology* (e.g. were research samples large/diverse enough)? How applicable is the information, is it just for Europe/USA, or can it be generalised across the world? Are there any points you disagree with?

Highlighter



You will locate key vocabulary & phrases from the text. Include both academic English phrases that you find useful for general writing, and ideally some discipline-specific phrases that your group could then use in the Timed Writing task on Friday.

You might have noticed some phrases being used across several texts in your weekly classes.

Contextualiser



You will put the text into context. This means using the internet to look at the people, academics, places, events, any important pieces of research etc. mentioned in the text.

Providing information about these details will help members to have a deeper understanding of the text in particular and the subject in general.

Visualiser



This creative role is aimed at finding information in the text that could be graphically or pictorially represented.

It could be pictures of people, places, maps mentioned in the text, as well as graphs and charts based on the data (self-made or found online).

Summariser



Your job is to summarise the key points of the text - don't spend a long time writing a summary and reading to everyone, but be prepared to give people a general idea of what the text is saying as and when needed.

Procedure



You will now be given a role for today - you'll have 15 mins to prepare for it & then have your first Academic Interaction, which will last 25-30 minutes.

As a first attempt and with limited time to prepare, this session is unlikely to run very smoothly; however, it will clearly highlight areas you should consider for next time and will help you to think of strategies to maintain contributions as a group.

Sit with people who have the same role, and prepare.

You now have 25-30 Mins to Discuss



Reflection



As a group, discuss:

- How was your interaction overall? Were you pleased with it? Why/why not?
- Did you manage to discuss, or was it more like turn-by-turn ‘presentations’?
- Were there any silences/gaps? How did you deal with them?
- What else went well, and what else went wrong?
- Can you think of any ways to address any problems for next time?

Preparation for Next Week



Although you have different roles, it's everyone's responsibility to make the discussion work; don't wait for the leader to organise you: contribute, interact, listen, respond. Feel free to:

- Interrupt (politely)
- Ask questions; general questions for everyone can help discussion
- Make comments about your opinion
- Raise something you didn't understand
- Build on or add to someone else's point
- Return to a previously mentioned point or change topic
- Agree/disagree

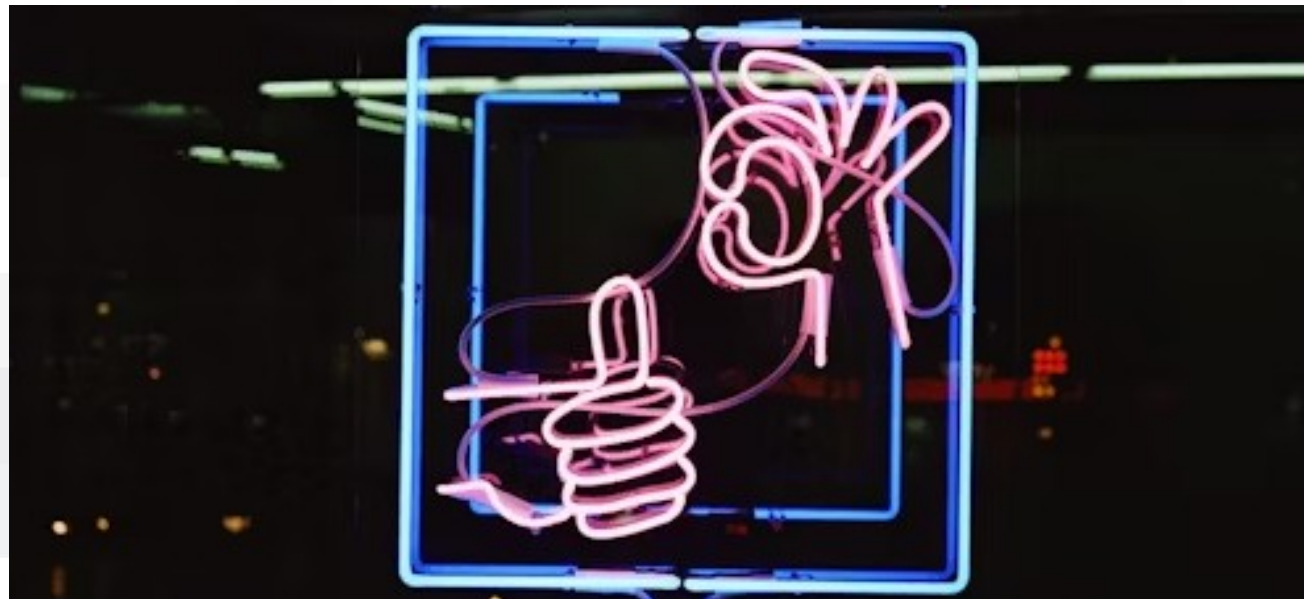
As mentioned earlier, don't be limited by your role.

Feedback



These classes are not assessed, but you'll receive feedback & general comments from your tutor from next week to help you improve.

Again, this advice may be useful for the final speaking assessment.



Prepare: 10-15 mins.



Your teacher will now assign you your roles for next week. Sit with someone who has the same role as you and discuss how you might approach it.

Your topic next week will be about **Gender** - the text is on Moodle.

Again, this text is not covered in the classes, you need to self-study. Also, you will not have time to prepare for the Interaction in the class, so make sure you arrive prepared.